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OCTOBER 35 CENTS

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the integrated Man of tomorrow

THE HAPPY HERD





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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK DEAREST
ENEMY ***

Dearest Enemy

BY FOX HOLDEN

*Well trained actors are taught
the old tradition that the
show must go on. But what's
the point of it all when your
audience is very, very dead?*

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From somewhere there was a buzzing sound. It kept repeating. The gentle throb of it vibrated his eardrums; the vibrations registered somewhere at the bottom edges of his brain. Buzzzz. Insistently, like a wasp. Like a trapped wasp.... But there were no wasps in the streamlined metal shell of Vanguard-I.

Better answer, another part of his brain whispered. *Better answer ... they want to tell you what to do....*

God!

Some sweat oozed from the dark bunches of his eyebrows, fogged the binocular eye-piece of the orbit-synchronized refractor, but he kept watching, he could not stop watching. *Buzzzz! Buzzzz!*

Red goutts of flame, as big as a pin-head, as big as a shirt-button, as big as—damn the fogging—up! No, no it was the mushrooms, not the fogging; you could count them, like puffs of gunsmoke along a firing-line stippling the Atlantic seaboard, now branching, riddling westward—others drifting eastward from the Pacific as though groping toward a pre-planned rendezvous.

Buzzzz! Buzzzz!

He would answer. There would be the sound of another man's voice and that would make it all real. If he silenced the buzzer and listened to the voice it would be real and not a final training-film; the films would be over, the lectures over, the flight-tests over, the eliminations over and he and Streeter chosen and Streeter dead and buried at Space and now he was alone up in Vanguard-I....

Vanguard-I was "up" and Earth was "down" and both were real. Beyond the buzzing, both would be real.

The strong young voice was an old voice as it answered the buzzing, as it gave sound to words for the UHF's panel-mike.

"Home Plate, Home Plate, this is Mrs. Grundy, over..."

"Mrs. Grundy this is Home Plate. Are you reading? Are you ready for a circus or is all your money gone? Over..."

"Ready for a circus. Regret delay in acknowledging. I—was in Observation, over."

"Mrs. Grundy, your Daddy-o wants to talk to you so bye bye baby...."

General Knight himself. Knight himself to talk to him ... so it was that bad.

Of course it was that bad!

"Mrs. Grundy can you read, over...." Knight's voice. It sounded calm. It sounded unruffled. You had to know Knight, you had to have heard him often to know that it was not calm, that it was not at all unruffled....

"Even the small print Daddy-o, over...."

"No words twice so baby make marks—" Thorn's hand flashed to the card-punch and magnetic-tape unit switches, flicked them to ON-RECORD. "—been surprised, but not taken completely off balance; retaliation now in progress as you have probably already observed or will observe in course of orbital passage. Plan Able Zebra effective immediately...." The words were coming so fast they were slurred, and Knight was exaggerating his own Alabama accent. "Expect report once each turn...."

He would not have needed the recording or even words twice. Each of Knight's directions was graven into him as it was spoken.

To cease all scientific observation and recording at once; to begin military observation of the Enemy and his puppet-states, and all possibly-discernible activities, immediately. To remember that as the coast of California appeared on his horizon he was to begin transmitting in code, and that he would finish transmitting before the Atlantic coast disappeared over the horizon behind him. To remember that his stores of fuel were for orbit-correction only, to be used for effecting an Earthside landing only upon explicit and properly-coded order, or upon threat of otherwise unavoidable destruction. To calculate present stores of food concentrate and air to the hour if possible, not forgetting that with Streeter gone the time-lapse between rendezvous with the supply rocket should be at least doubled. To remember a thousand things; things he already knew by rote ... but the tape and card-punch units clicked softly away, recording, recording....

"... and Mrs. Grundy here's a morsel for you—you may have a new neighbor in your block but not like you at all—there's probably a world

between you—don't take any wooden nickels baby. Say good-bye to Daddy-o baby, over...."

"Home Plate this is Mrs. Grundy sees all and heard everything, out."

The whole transmission had taken less than two minutes. Now the UHF was off and there was one break, anyway. If, somehow, the Enemy had succeeded in getting up a satellite of his own, he had at least—according to Knight—sacrificed the ability to directly monitor Thorn's radio for invisibility. Vanguard-I was aloft for geophysical purposes only, according to the propaganda-pitch back home. But as far as Big Red knew, it was loaded to the locks with as much armament as a thing of its comparatively tiny size could carry.

And as far as Thorn himself knew, nobody making geophysical observations had ever needed to do it through the tubes of missile-launchers like the ones that were cuddled snugly in Vanguard-I's blunt forehull....

Such little thoughts whipped quickly through his mind as he tried to make it regain balance for the immediate tasks besetting him, because they were little and simple and easy to grasp and discard. They could keep him from going crazy. It was the bigger thoughts—the bigger ones that might come later—they were the kind he had to keep out of his head.

Major Joshua Thorn began his work with the equipment, to modify it for use as Daddy-o had told him.

He could do it automatically, do it in his sleep, do it blind. Couldn't watch and do it, though. Watch later. Think of the little things now that were easy while the equipment got automatically modified. Little things to keep the big ones like what was happening down there from tipping him over into the whirlpool of madness that was trying so hard to pull at him.

Little things....

"Please be seated, Major Thorn."

"Yes sir."

"This will be your Final Security interrogation. To be followed, upon its favorable completion, by Final Briefing. Before we begin, do you have any questions, Major?"

The thick lenses of the glasses reflected the interrogation cubicle's harsh lighting and would not let him see accurately into the pale eyes that blinked behind them. But it was almost as though he and Brigadier Robert McQuine, USAF, Intelligence, were old friends. And the sweating faces of the three G-2 psychiatrists that gleamed at McQuine's left on the opposite end of the big oval-shaped conference-table—they were more than familiar. They had never thought he, Thorn, was really sane. What really sane man who had flown twice too many missions in one war would volunteer to fly in the next that followed? What sane man would go begging for military flight-test assignments in weird ships that had never been flown anywhere but in a wind-tunnel and on computer-tapes. And what sane man—God help him—what man in his senses would ask to be fired a thousand miles off the Earth with only the knowledge that a thing the size of a basketball had circled the planet successfully for almost a year before it fell back and burned up?

Had the Major ever had thoughts of—well, of doing away with himself? Had the Major hated his father when he was young? Been afraid of girls? (Oh, is that a fact, Major? Well! Well, now....)

Only the faces of the three Senate Committee members were different. But they usually were.

"Yes sir, one question. It was my understanding—and Captain Streeter's, I'm sure—that Final Security and Briefing had been scheduled for about nine weeks from now. There has been no acceleration in the final phases of our program, so—"

"I, ah—" McQuine interrupted smoothly, "think that question might best be answered by your Final Briefing officers, Major. Now, any other questions?"

"No sir." So that was it, all right. The rumors, as usual, had a germ of truth in them. All rumors did. And these had been more persistent than most. *Cold war not so cold anymore. General Adams transferring. That last note from Big Red—didn't all get to the papers! Cold war not so cold anymore....*

"Now, Major, when you were a sophomore in high-school—the book entitled *A World United* not on your required English or Political Science reading lists, was it?"

"No sir, not as I recall, but—"

"Then why did you read it? You have admitted before that you *did* read it —"

Pause. All up to him. Every single word, every single inflection, up to him....

"I took quite an interest in my studies, both in high-school and in college, sir, as I believe my records will show you. They'll show that I also read books relating to other courses that weren't a regular part of the curriculum...."

Nodding. But looking him squarely in the face, hesitating just the right length of time. Then suddenly "Major Thorn do you swear here and now in the presence of witnesses that your allegiance to your country comes first above all with the sole possible exception of Almighty God?"

"I do so swear...."

And on and on....

"... why did you major in the Fine Arts in high-school, switch to Engineering in college, then switch again to take your degrees in World History and Political Science ... were you ever heard to say, or reported to have said, or did you in fact say.... Major, I have here the records of...."

The Senators had their questions. The psychiatrists had theirs.

"... hesitation, Major, in firing upon an Enemy aircraft, even though disabled ... guilt-feeling at destroying a city containing almost one million people.... Major you told us that ... training for five years, now, and you realize...."

More and more and more, but it was not so difficult to keep his nerves straightened out as it had been the first time or the next time after that. He had told the absolute truth as far as he could possibly know it. So it was just a matter of giving the same answers he had always given. Let 'em make what they could of the truth....

"Yes, Senator, I readily admit having written my senior essay on the basis of the book *A World United*. Yes sir, I studied philosophy and some foreign languages in college.... No sir—no sir, nothing like that. No. Never...."

And then hardly an hour after it was all over, less than an hour to relax for Streeter and himself, cooped up in a single room with cigarettes and magazines and nothing else and nobody else to talk to, hardly an hour, and then Final Briefing was underway.

General Groton: Typical Orders of Procedure.

General Simms: Technical Details.

General Orton: Estimate of the Present Situation. *Rumors, hell....*

And then the Secretary of Defense himself.

"Major Thorn, Captain Streeter... There is probably little I can add to all that has been so thoroughly ingrained in you in your five years of training for this experiment, or learned by both of you, the hard way, in war. But there are certain points I feel I ought to emphasize personally ... even though I know you've heard them many, many times before.

"First, this is your country. In the adventure—in the duty, that you are about to undertake, there must be no mistake that your nation comes above *all* other considerations! Now, I don't question your devotion, I merely re-impress...."

Pause. The man was good, all right.

"Second, despite what you may have heard from—from any of various sources in recent months, our cold-war Enemy is hard-pressed; he is desperate, and he is likewise determined. Determined as even you may not guess. Our Intelligence has learned that he has trained women to bear arms as well as children for his armies. He has trained them to march, to bivouac, to fly intercontinental bombers, to fly rocket interceptors, to go to the attack with men—and on an equal basis, and in almost equal numbers. A point to remember, even from where you shall soon sit! Don't forget it.

"Last, if—and we all pray that it won't happen in this or any other generation—but, *if* war should come—if some unsuspecting midnight it should suddenly erupt (and such eruption would be on both our shores, smashing all of our greatest cities even as we retaliated) if this happens,

gentlemen, you must not forget one thing. You must not forget for an instant that in such a war, *all* the Enemy must die.

"If I sound melodramatic forgive me, and bear with me. You both realize, I'm certain, that any Next War would be a war to the death. After which—" the skillfully-modulated voice lowered, softened, paused, softened again.... "After which, there will be only one of us left. *Because there will be no time for armistice, for truce....* It will be Our Side, or Theirs. Gentlemen, it *must be Ours! So if there is war, I repeat, all the Enemy must die!*

"That's all I have, except to say good luck and God-speed."

Very firm hand-shake for each of them, and Final Briefing was over.

Even yet Joshua Thorn could remember that first emotion shared by himself and Streeter after the effects of the four-G blast-off had worn away, after the tension of establishing orbit was eased, the first report made to Home Plate, and they were at last granted a moment's rest, a moment's respite to look back, to realize....

Done it. Done it.... They had *done* it!

They could almost see themselves, the National Emblem emblazoned brilliantly on their chalk-white metal skin, riding in dignified, silent triumph over all of the Earth. Now let anybody—anybody, anybody anywhere (for weren't they above all of anywhere?) shake a fist, rattle a sabre!

First Men in Space. Like God, somehow....

They thudded each other on the back, they yelled things they could not remember, they let the tears flood down their cheeks without noticing, and they laughed; they laughed long and loudly with words and wordlessly, and then they watched again, watched mighty Earth below them turning by some power that was not theirs to see on an invisible spit over Infinity.

It was at the end of the fourth month that Streeter died.

"Josh? Josh what's our trouble?" Young, earnest. Wiry and pink-cheeked and an eternal glint of excitement in his light blue eyes.

Thorn kept studying the instruments as he answered, slowly, and without alarm in his voice. It wasn't much, but the bunching of his thick eyebrows had given him away. It always did.

"Port reflector's all, I guess, Johnny. Been watching it; a hair off, so we're down just enough BTU's to make a dent in power supply. Must have come out a little cockeyed when we popped it. Want to watch the panel a few minutes while I—"

"Second-guessed you, Skipper—" Johnny Streeter was already halfway into a pressure-suit. "Just zip me up the back and check my petticoat...."

Josh Thorn grinned, closed Johnny's suit, secured his soap-bubble helmet. They'd both been Out before so it wasn't as if this was the first time. It was just that this was the first time it *had* to be done.

"Suit-check, Johnny...."

"I read you—" crackled the bulkhead audio.

"Air?"

"Fourteen point seven psi, oxygen 26 per cent, nitrogen...."

They finished the check; all the complex machinery of Baggy-Drawers was functioning perfectly. Then Instrument Check—Methodically, Johnny's gauntleted mitts touched each magnetic hook on the wide girdle, named each implement suspended from it, replaced it.

"Can I go out and play now?"

"Be a good boy, Johnny."

The lock hissed, cycled down, and then Thorn was hearing the metallic noises of Johnny's feet striding ponderously like some story-book Colossus along the "upper" hull, sternward, and then to port.

"Be a cinch, Josh," the audio crackled. "If they're all this easy I'll feel like a draft-dodger! Maybe if I swab the deck while I'm ou—" A sound that wasn't Johnny but it was.

"Johnny? Johnny, do you read me?" Josh Thorn could feel sweat dripping on his stomach. "Johnny—"

He left the mike, made his way aft in clumsy haste, the simulated gravity confusing long-conditioned reflexes. And he listened beneath the hull section over which Johnny would be. Listened for a thump, a scrape of metal on metal, a vibration of life....

Nothing.

His own Baggy-Drawers seemed built for a midget with one leg as he struggled into it. cursory check—enough, she worked, she'd have to....

Out. Aft. Port. Johnny....

Johnny Streeter was still standing, but it was an odd kind of stance; the stance of a marionette on slack strings. Motionless. Standing by the reflector mast, some of his magnetized instruments clinging to it.

And then he saw Johnny Streeter's helmet, and saw that it was no longer transparent. Josh tasted vomit on his lips.

A chance in how many million, how many billion? What was it the statisticians had said? About the same chance as a fatal auto accident, having a meteor hit you....

Equipment converted, recalibrated for Earthside observation. Equipment checked. Emergency reflectors out (power drain still damned heavy) and radar full out; close-down scanners on, recording equipment humming, ready.... Coast coming up in—oh-nine minutes, three-seven seconds. Tapes ready at play-back, UHF set.

Now wait.

You can watch while you wait....

His eyes hurt, their sockets hurt as he pressed them too hard into the binocular eye-piece.

Damn the fogging! Damn the blue fogging—*blue*?

No!

It filled the object-lens; it swirled, it calmed, it coalesced, it thinned, and there was a second's sight through it, and then Josh Thorn was swinging the refractor in near-abandon on its panhead ... there! Clear! Clear, you could see—at the edges! Coming in again, drifting, drifting slowly, drifting ... blind.

His fingertips slipped, grabbed again, swung the telescope too violently, steadied.

Blue fog, moving slowly, deliberately, and yet so fast, so unbelievably fast, why, they said if it ever happened it would take weeks, months, maybe years, but they could've been wrong, so many things they couldn't have known....

Blue.

Cobalt blue.

With some force of sheer power of reason, Joshua Thorn forced himself from the refractor; forced himself past the blue-faced scanners (maybe it was only an Enemy trick; an Enemy screen, the biggest blue smoke-screen ever made!) to the UHF. Maybe. Sure. He was overdue. Minutes overdue; they were waiting for him down there, waiting for his call, wondering if perhaps the screen had really fooled him, or if it were really effective in blocking his sight, or if....

They were right down there, right underneath him, waiting under the blue smoke-screen.

"Home Plate Home Plate this is Mrs. Grundy over...."

Crackling.

"Home Plate Home Plate this is Mrs. Grundy. Home Plate Home Plate what's the matter can't you read? Home Plate Home Plate this is Mrs. Grundy, over.... *Over!*"

Crackling.

The meters.... All right—on the nose, right. What were they, asleep down there? Maybe the smoke-screen reflected even UHF. He could try a bounce and see. Narrow beam. Tight. Watch the screen....

Pip. Pip. Pip.

Getting through. Lousy smoke, just couldn't see through it....

"Home Plate Home Plate Home Plate—"

He had been around fifty times; he had counted. It had taken one hundred hours; he had counted. He had transmitted steadily since the twentieth time, in the few languages he knew beside his own, for sixty hours; he had counted.

He had only a whisper for a voice now, and only aching places where his ears were.

But it didn't matter. It didn't matter.

"Home Plate, this Mrs. Grundy—

"Can anyone read me? Does anyone read me down there?

"Kann jedermann mich hören? Antworten-Sie, bitte...."

"Repondez, repondez si vous m'entendrez...."

"Damn you can't you hear me CAN'T YOU HEAR ME?"

He'd tried to keep track of the time.

He thought it had been a month; maybe more, but a month anyway.

And now the blue was solid over Earth, over all of it. There were still little swirls, little eddies of it here and there, but most of it—already, most of it had settled like a fixed shell, like the quiescent surface of a stagnant pool.

And somehow he'd accepted it.

They were all dead down there.

Cobalt blue had killed them all, killed them all....

Funny. It had a rhythm to it. Cobalt blue had killed them all, killed them all, Cobalt bombs had killed them all—

STOP IT!

But if they were all dead....

And if he were not dead....

Then he was the last human being left alive.

That was crazy.

Nobody could be—nobody could be the last—

But there was nobody.

Except him. So, it followed: therefore—ergo: logically, if there was nobody, and if....

God, it was dark.

God, it was quiet.

And if....

If you laugh you'll go crazy.

If you don't laugh, if you don't laugh, if you—hell, only one dose of barbiturate left in the First Aid stores ... big thing, hard to swallow ... and if there's nobody left, then....

Sleep.

He hadn't touched the UHF in three months, but he'd left it on regardless of the power drain just in case.

He had divided the hours off into sleeping and eating periods, and he had just slept, and just eaten, and he'd shaved, and put on a fresh uniform. He had knotted the tie perfectly; his collar insignia were shined and pinned in place without a single wrinkle.

He had it figured out.

He could die of oxygen, if not food, starvation in five more months, three and one-half more days. And that would be the end of it.

The hell it would! Who the hell did they think they were to do this to him....

But he had his computers. He had his reference-tapes. He had his refractor and his scanners, and his star-charts, and his store of fuel for orbital correction (ninety percent of which remained, because it had been an almost perfect shot) and he had his brains.

If you threw a stone off the rear of a moving train at a speed *less* than the train's speed forward, the stone would of course leave the train, but in relation to the ground would still be travelling in the train's direction.

If you threw a satellite away from its path around Earth and directly into Earth's wake, but at a speed less than Earth's forward speed in its orbit, the satellite would break free, but would continue in Earth's orbital direction. And then with a brief side-blast, you could warp into an orbit around the Sun all your own, or—into that of the planet Venus, if you chose....

And beneath that eternal shell of cloud—who knew?

He had his computers. He had his reference-tapes. He had his refractor and his scanners, and his star-charts and his precious store of fuel. (Three-score years and ten, the Good Book said. Better than five months. Better than sitting and waiting. So he would fail—no worse than what was Below.) And he had his brains.

He worked methodically. He drew schedules: four hours of work, one for eating and relaxation; five hours more of work, and another for food and rest; six hours more of work, then seven for sleep, and then the cycle began again. By making a rhythm of it, he thought, rather than a program of perfectly equal work-periods, he would avoid monotony. With monotony would come despair, and with despair.... Despair of course would kill him.

And there was the thing in him that would not be killed; a thing that had been rooted as deep within his kind as Life itself, since the first Man had shambled erect on the face of the still-steaming Earth. He would survive.

As Joshua Thorn, and as Man. He would not let Man die yet. Not out here. Not in the cold dark, alone. Somehow, Thorn thought, Man had earned a better way, a better place to die....

But of course it was silly to think that Man should ever die, that he *could* ever die....

Ridiculous.

Baloney. Oh, you could kill a lot of people, certainly. Sure. But the whole race of Man—nuts to the philosophers! The only thing they knew how to do was think!

He worked methodically, ascertaining first that at the present point in her orbital swing, Venus, approaching as she was from aphelion, would be in close enough proximity as she passed by to be met within the time limit set by his remaining store of food and oxygen. And he ascertained secondly that he had sufficient "emergency" fuel (and this, he assumed, might be classified as an emergency of sorts?) to blast him out of orbit and into Earth's wake with barely sufficient speed to assure him of not falling back. If the computers weren't lying, there'd even be enough after that to warp him into the gradual, drifting arc that would intercept Venus in her path around the Sun, and then—perhaps enough to effect landing. Barely, if at all. His taut mouth twitched in a humorless little smile. What an irony to actually succeed—to make it all the way, across the millions of miles of Space, first human in history to accomplish it—and then, maybe one or two hundred feet above surface, to have the final drop of fuel run out....

So ... what was there to lose but the race of Man.... And that anyway, eventually. Thirty-five more years (if he were lucky; he smiled again) appended to—how many? Half a million?

But half a million years was only a nervous twitch on the skin of Time. A spark in an eternal, all-consuming fire; a spark that died even as it flared its little second and then crumbled into ashes.

He smiled a grim little smile, and made a note of the date; it was 1800 hours, October 21. He did not even glance at the pale-blue thing that rolled and shimmered grotesquely a scant thousand miles on his left. Be damned to you! But you are damned already. So good-bye.

His fingers finished the business of tightening the heavy buckle of his seat-belt, and then they punched the red firing-studs, and Vanguard-I broke her bondage.

The ferroelectric brains of the computers considered silently; acted.

The organic brain of the man hazed red, hazed darkly, and trusted, for it was powerless to do more save fight a primal struggle for consciousness. It could not regard the situation. It could not think: I am the first human being to fly Space. It could not think, of all the things that all the humans in all of history have ever done, I alone have done this.

Roll the drums for Agamemnon, Roll the drums for Hercules!

Roll the drums for Caesar, Alexander, for Amenhotep, Rameses ... drum the drums for Khan, for Suleiman, for Plato, Aristides—drum your drums for York and Tudor, Bacon, Michelangelo.... For Austerlitz. For Yorktown. Chickamauga, Ypres, and Anzio....

Roll the drums. Roll the drums for me....

Motors off.

Click-hum, computers....

Silently.

Wheel your eternal wheeling, stars.

Darkly.

Cold.

The screens showed white, thick white, and the fuel-pumps disgorged the remainder of Vanguard I's life-blood into the roaring combustion chambers. The muted complaining of heavy atmosphere keened up the scale to a

banshee's lament and sweat poured from Josh Thorn's half-nude body as his tiny metal cell grew stifling.

Power—how much power to keep from becoming a vagrant meteorite in Venus' milky skies? From flaring, white-hot, and falling ... a cinder from nowhere, with nowhere to go, the last of Earth's ashes....

One hundred miles.

Fifty. Thirty. Twelve....

Cooler, now. He shivered in 105 degrees Fahrenheit, shivered in 99, in 87.... His sweat was cold.

Ten thousand feet! Slowing, slowing, a century of time to drop to nine thousand, ease off the power, eight thousand, steady; fuel, barely, six thousand, steady.... Steady.

Watch your screens! Green. Brown, yellow, blue-veined green; low-rolling magenta mountains westward, cloud-shadows rippling, mingling with tenuous wisps of steam ... steam from the jungles of tall forest....

One thousand feet. No sign of mobile life on this planet, in this valley into which Vanguard-I lowered. But all sign—all sign, indeed, of the rich lushness that would support it, embrace it, hold it close like a long-denied lover....

Thorn sweated again—hot sweat, now—at his scanners, his control panel. Temperature again hovering past 100, but there was no time to notice or to feel. One hundred feet ... gently....

And then Vanguard-I was down, and at rest.

Josh Thorn hesitated. Baggy-Drawers? Or not? Beneath the white, tenuous outer atmospheric shell of methane and ammonia, what? Air he could breathe? Or poison that would strangle him—

He swung the inner air-lock open.

If poison, then death would be but a matter of days; the bubble of Made-in-U.S.A. atmosphere that he'd brought thirty million miles across Space had supplied him for the nearly four months the Journey had taken. It had done its job, he could demand no more than that. Two weeks more, at best, and it would be spent forever.

Two weeks, thirty-five years, five thousand centuries—

He swung the outer air-lock open.

And breathed. And breathed. And breathed deeply again.

Joshua Thorn wanted to cry. There was a hurt in his throat, and he wanted to yell, and he wanted to laugh great peals of laughter even as the unchecked salt tears streamed across the deep valleys of his cheeks.

He walked, he ran. He stopped, he turned his face to the sky, he spread his arms wide and let the great bellows of laughter roll from his lips in the lusty prayer of thanks that only the living who are full with life and amid the teeming fullness of life can know.

Thank you, God. Thank you God. Thank you....

(For this little while more, for this little while more for the race of Man; I am the last of Man, You know—)

He prayed thank you, but he did not pray for more, because this was already more than he deserved; the Almighty had been merciful, compassionate and merciful, and he could not ask for more, in no way dared ask—

The thunder seemed straight above him.

The sound of his own laughter had drowned it out at first, and then the two had mingled, and then as he stood gasping for new breath, as his hoarse voice rested, he heard it—welling as if from a great heavy throat, and now rising to a baleful cry, then falling—falling gently, and now a new thunder to drown it, a mightier thunder than the first.

Joshua Thorn stood transfixed as he watched the gleaming bullet-shape descend its pillar of fire. It could have been twin to Vanguard-I. It was descending—it was—*maneuvering* to be near him!

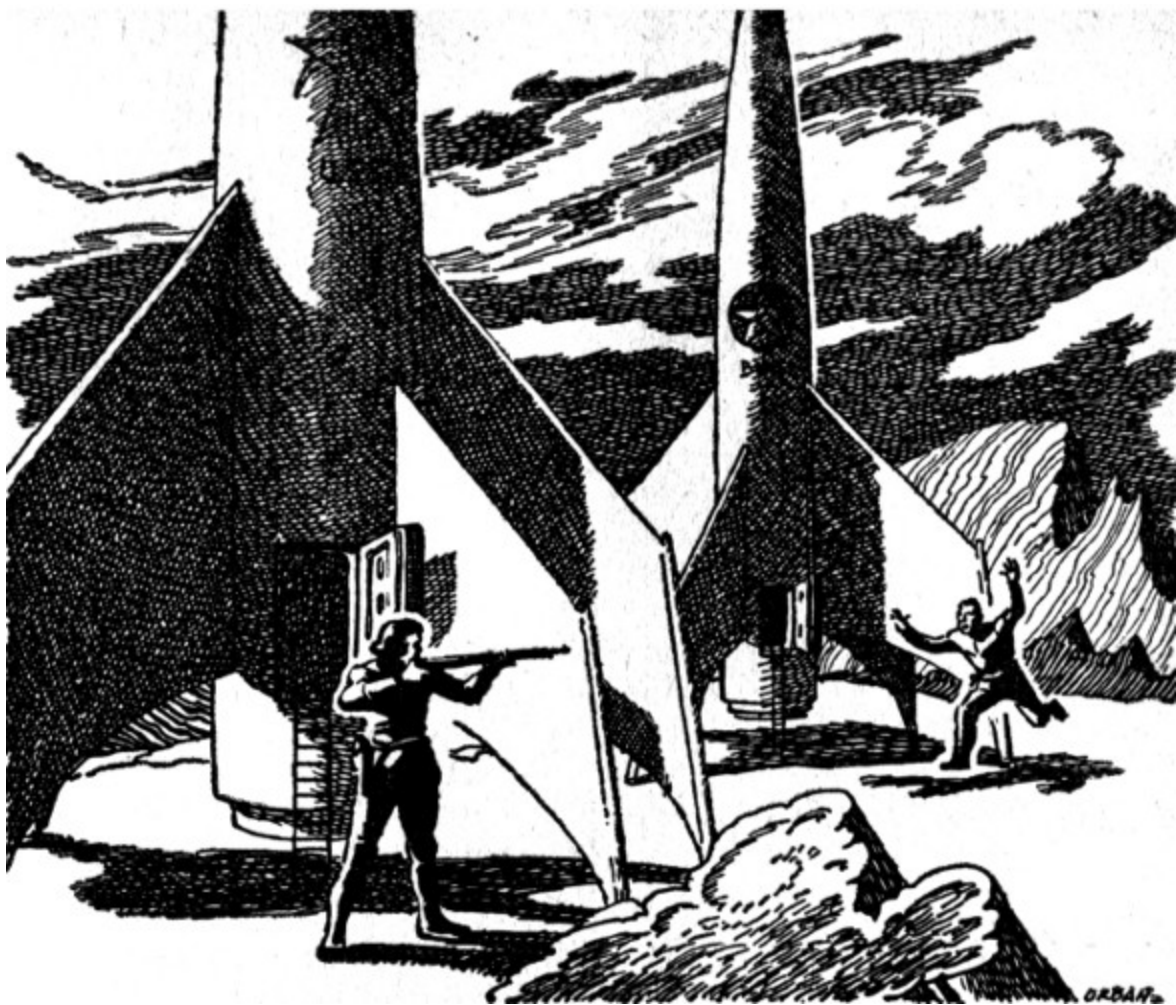
From somewhere far back in his brain the words formed again, *and Mrs. Grundy here's dirt for you—you may have a new neighbor in your block but not like you at all—probably a world between you—don't take any wooden nickels....*

But Daddy-o could never know, would never comprehend—

He was running, stumbling, falling, running again toward the spot where the red-starred satellite of the Enemy (Enemy, what a madman's word now!) would land.

Running like a child, running like an idiot, arms waving, mouth laughing, throat shouting—

Thank you, oh *Thank* you God....



He was within twenty yards of the craft when its outer lock opened. Fifteen when the uniformed figure who stepped out caught sight and sound of him, ten when the rifle was aimed at him, five before he could comprehend the mindless meaning of it—

But we are the only two human beings left! his brain whimpered....

All of the Enemy must die! a remembering part of his mind intoned.... But someone had trained the Enemy, too.

The scarlet insigne emblazoned on the streamlined metal shell seemed on fire in the filtered Venusian sunlight.

Thorn's plunging hands grabbed the muzzle of the weapon even as it fired, wrenched it aside without feeling the hurt where his left earlobe had been.

"Great God, you *imbecile*—"

Twisting the weapon, struggling, trigger-finger constricting to fire again, a final, sudden twist, the finger wrenched against the trigger even as the butt was swinging upward, the muzzle swinging down....

The muffled explosion.

The gaping, oozing hole in the Enemy's breast.

Joshua Thorn looked down at the crumpled figure, watched as the slow-moving shadow of a cloud eddied across it.

He tried to sob, for he could not pray again.

He turned. Back toward Vanguard-I. If only he could cry.

Behind him, the Enemy lay dead. All, now, all of the Enemy ... was dead.

Her body would soon be turning cold.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK DEAREST ENEMY

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